



Change of guard again: Babar Azam took over Pakistan's T20I captaincy from Shaheen Shah Afridi earlier this year. AFP

may often be called upon to roll his arm over for the full quota of four overs. The tournament will also mark the return of Pant to international cricket after a horrific car accident kept him away from the game for more than a year. He has been impressive in the IPL for Delhi Capitals, having scored 446 runs in 13 innings at an average of 40.55 and a strike-rate of 155.40.

What do Ireland, USA and Canada bring to the table?

Although Canada went down by 86 runs to Bermuda in the opening game of the Americas qualifier, an amazing recovery saw it seal a debut appearance in the quest for the biggest prize in T20 cricket. Under the able leadership of all-rounder Saad Bin Zafar, it defeated the Cayman Islands twice and Panama by margins of 100-plus runs each time to set up a date with Bermuda

again in the final. This time, though, it got the better of the host.

However, in April, Canada got a reality check when it toured the US for a five-match series, where Monank Patel and Steven Taylor's pyrotechnics coupled with Harmeet Singh's economical spells resigned the visitor to a 4-0 series drubbing (one match was abandoned). Despite the commanding win, what would bother the host nation is the limited gametime it has had leading into the tournament. Before the said series, it last played a match in July 2022.

Canada, the sole Americas qualifier, and host USA will play the tournament-opener on June 1 at the Grand Prairie Stadium in Dallas.

Having featured in all men's T20 World Cups since 2009, Ireland is a certified giant-killer. And this time, nothing is different.

The side has gone with an experienced line-up, retaining an overwhelming 11 of its squad of 15 in 2022.

Two teams that will qualify

In Group A, it's evident who the

top two will be without much thought.

Ireland will have to come up with the performance of a lifetime to be able to remove either India or Pakistan from the top two slots ahead of the 'Super 8' stage.

The USA and Canada will be here for the 'big-match' experience. They need to keep their nose to the grindstone and any positive outcome that comes along the way will remain an unforgettable moment.

Dark horse

Ireland is a glowing example for the Davids of the world. It has sent Goliath packing, not once but many times over. Both Pakistan and Afghanistan have fallen prey once in 2024.

Against India, in August 2023, Craig Young had removed Yashasvi Jaiswal and Tilak Varma off successive deliveries shortly before the match got called off due to rain. India had saved its blushes with a two-run victory via DLS.

In March 2023, it hammered Bangladesh at the latter's home.